

Yacht Away Now: Partnership & Brokerage Proposal

Prepared by: Ciaran Wentz & Josh Wilson

Date: April 24, 2026

Version: Draft 1.0

1. Executive Summary

This proposal outlines a two-tier business model for Yacht Away Now:

- **Tier 1 — Own Fleet:** Josh provides 100% of vessel capital; Ciaran provides 100% of the business build-out (platform, AI, SEO, marketing). 60/40 profit split (Josh/Ciaran).
- **Tier 2 — Brokerage Platform:** Other yacht owners list vessels on yachtawaynow.com; we facilitate bookings and take a 30-45% commission

The goal is to build a scalable charter platform in the Tampa Bay market that generates income from both owned assets and brokerage fees with minimal marginal cost per listing.

2. Tier 1: Co-Owned Yacht Operations

2.1 Ownership & Acquisition Models

The core deal: Josh provides 100% of the capital (vessel purchase, slip fees, insurance, maintenance). Ciaran provides 100% of the business build-out (platform, AI systems, SEO, marketing, booking engine, brokerage infrastructure). Profit split: 60% Josh / 40% Ciaran — reflecting Josh's greater financial risk as the capital partner.

2.2 Partnership Structure — Capital vs. Build

Partner	Contribution	Estimated Value
Josh	Vessel purchase/financing, slip fees, insurance, maintenance, fuel, captain/crew, USCG licensing	\$67K - \$182K/yr per vessel
Ciaran	Website & platform development, AI automation (inquiry responder, review management), SEO & digital marketing, booking system, brokerage platform build-out, ongoing tech operations	\$60K - \$150K+ in build value, ongoing

Why 60/40 is fair:

- Josh takes on 100% of the financial risk — capital is at stake from day one

- Ciaran's contributions (platform, AI, SEO) are essential but carry no capital risk
- 60/40 rewards Josh's financial exposure while recognizing that without Ciaran's build-out, the vessel generates zero bookings
- Charter management companies charge 30-50% just for the marketing/booking side — Ciaran's 40% share covers that AND the brokerage platform build
- As the brokerage scales, both partners benefit proportionally from the platform Ciaran built

2.3 What Each Partner Brings

Josh's Capital Contributions:

- Down payment or full purchase of vessel(s)
- Monthly slip/marina fees
- Commercial charter insurance
- Maintenance, repairs, winterization
- Fuel costs (or passed to customer)
- Captain/crew compensation — captains to operate and manage the vessel
- USCG licensing and compliance costs

Ciaran's Build Contributions:

- yachtawaynow.com — full platform development and hosting
- AI automations, consulting, and agent build-out and management
- AI-powered instant inquiry responder (already built)
- Google review auto-responder (in progress)
- GetMyBoat auto-draft system (built, pending deployment)
- Content creation and management (social media, blog, video, brand)
- Google My Business management (GBP optimization, posts, reviews)
- Local SEO strategy and execution driving organic bookings
- Brokerage platform — owner onboarding, listing pages, commission tracking
- Payment processing integration (Stripe)
- Booking management dashboard
- Attending networking events and building business partnerships
- Ongoing platform maintenance, feature development, and marketing

2.4 Profit-Sharing Structure

Rule	Details
Split	60% Josh / 40% Ciaran after all operating expenses
Expense Priority	All vessel + platform costs paid first from gross revenue

Rule	Details
Reserve Fund	Maintain 2 months of operating expenses before distributions
Distribution Schedule	Monthly or quarterly (agree on cadence)
Capital Expenditures	Mutual approval required above \$1,000
Vessel Equity	Vessel is titled under the LLC; Josh holds 60%, Ciaran holds 40%
Platform IP	Platform IP is owned by the LLC; Josh holds 60%, Ciaran holds 40%

2.5 Additional Vessel Acquisition Models (For Scaling)

Model A — Revenue-Funded Acquisition

- Use brokerage + charter profits to fund the down payment on additional vessels
- The LLC buys the boat — cleaner for taxes and liability
- No additional personal capital required from either partner
- **Best for:** Vessel #2 and beyond once cash flow is proven

Model B — Lease-to-Charter (Asset-Light)

- Lease or rent a vessel on a monthly/seasonal basis instead of purchasing
- Charter it out at a markup
- Lower upfront capital (\$3K-\$8K/month lease vs. \$30K+ down payment)
- Can upgrade or swap vessels seasonally based on demand
- **Best for:** Testing a new vessel type or market segment with minimal risk

Model C — Fractional / Syndicate Ownership

- Bring in 2-4 outside investors who each own a percentage of a vessel
- Ciaran & Josh manage operations via the LLC and take a management fee (10-15% of gross) plus profit share
- Investors get passive income from charter revenue
- **Best for:** Scaling to a 3-5 vessel fleet without Josh over-leveraging on capital

Model D — Vessel Partnership with Existing Owners

- Partner with someone who already owns a yacht but isn't using it enough
- We market, book, and manage charters on their vessel
- Split: 30-45% to us (see Tier 2 commission structure), 55-70% to owner
- Owner covers insurance, maintenance, and slip fees since it's their asset
- **Best for:** Zero capital required, immediate inventory, easy to pitch to underutilized yacht owners

2.6 Recommended Growth Path

Phase 1 (Months 1-6): Josh funds first vessel. Ciaran launches platform, AI systems, and SEO. Begin taking bookings on own vessel + recruit first 5 brokerage owners (Model D). Prove the model.

Phase 2 (Months 7-12): Use proven booking data and cash flow to add brokerage listings aggressively. Evaluate adding a second vessel via Model A (revenue-funded) or Model B (lease).

Phase 3 (Year 2+): Scale fleet via Model C (syndicate investors) or Model A purchases funded by cash flow. Brokerage platform becomes the primary growth engine with 30+ listed vessels.

2.2 Cost Breakdown (Estimated, Per Vessel)

Expense Category	Annual Estimate	Monthly Estimate
Vessel Purchase/Financing	\$30,000 - \$80,000/yr	\$2,500 - \$6,700
Slip/Marina Fees	\$6,000 - \$18,000/yr	\$500 - \$1,500
Insurance (commercial charter)	\$3,000 - \$8,000/yr	\$250 - \$667
Maintenance & Repairs	\$5,000 - \$15,000/yr	\$417 - \$1,250
Fuel (per-trip, passed to customer or absorbed)	\$3,000 - \$8,000/yr	\$250 - \$667
Captain/Crew (if not owner-operated)	\$15,000 - \$40,000/yr	\$1,250 - \$3,333
Cleaning & Turnaround	\$2,000 - \$5,000/yr	\$167 - \$417
Marketing & Platform Costs	\$2,000 - \$5,000/yr	\$167 - \$417
Licensing & USCG Compliance	\$1,000 - \$3,000/yr	\$83 - \$250
Total Annual Overhead	\$67,000 - \$182,000	\$5,584 - \$15,201

2.3 Revenue Projections (Own Vessel)

Scenario	Bookings/Month	Avg Booking Value	Monthly Gross	Annual Gross
Conservative	8	\$800	\$6,400	\$76,800
Moderate	14	\$900	\$12,600	\$151,200
Aggressive	20	\$1,000	\$20,000	\$240,000

2.4 Profit Projection (Own Vessel)

Scenario	Annual Revenue	Annual Expenses	Net Profit	Josh (60%)	Ciaran (40%)
Conservative	\$76,800	\$100,000	-\$23,200	-\$13,920	-\$9,280
Moderate	\$151,200	\$120,000	\$31,200	\$18,720	\$12,480
Aggressive	\$240,000	\$140,000	\$100,000	\$60,000	\$40,000

Breakeven point: ~11-12 bookings/month at \$900 avg (depending on expense tier)

2.5 Profit-Sharing Rules

1. All revenue deposited into the LLC operating account
2. Expenses paid first from gross revenue each month
3. Maintain a reserve fund (recommended: 2 months of expenses)
4. Remaining profit distributed monthly or quarterly per 60/40 split (Josh/Ciaran)
5. Capital expenditures (new equipment, vessel upgrades) require mutual approval above \$1,000

3. Tier 2: Brokerage Platform Model

3.1 Concept

Yacht Away Now operates as a booking platform where third-party yacht owners list their vessels. We handle marketing, booking management, payment processing, and customer service. Owners handle the actual charter operations.

3.2 Commission Structure Options

Model	Our Commission	Owner Gets	Best For
A — Flat 30%	30% of booking	70%	Standard — owner provides vessel + crew, we do everything else
B — Full-Service 40-45%	40-45% of booking	55-60%	We handle marketing, booking, customer service, payment, AND crew coordination
C — Tiered by Volume	40% first \$5K/mo, 30% above	Scales with volume	Rewards high-performing vessels, keeps owners motivated
D — Subscription + Commission	\$199/mo + 30%	70% minus sub fee	Premium owners wanting guaranteed platform commitment

Why 30-45% is justified:

- We're not just a listing site — we're a full-service booking and marketing engine
- AI-powered instant inquiry responses convert leads that owners would otherwise lose
- Professional SEO drives organic traffic owners can't generate themselves
- Payment processing, customer service, and review management are all handled
- Charter management companies typically charge 30-50%, so this is market rate
- GetMyBoat charges ~20% but provides minimal marketing — our value-add justifies the premium

Recommended: Start at 35% flat for standard listings, 45% for full-service (where we also coordinate crew scheduling and handle all customer communication end-to-end). Owners who bring their own bookings through the platform pay 30%.

3.3 Value Proposition to Yacht Owners

- **Full booking pipeline** — We drive leads, respond instantly with AI, close bookings, and handle payment
- **Local SEO dominance** — Tampa Bay focused, not buried in a national marketplace with 10,000 listings
- **AI-powered inquiry response** — Instant draft replies to booking inquiries (already built) — owners lose leads when they take 6+ hours to respond; we respond in minutes
- **Professional listing pages** — High-quality photos, optimized descriptions, review integration
- **Review management** — Automated Google review responses building social proof
- **Zero effort bookings** — Owner just shows up, does the charter, gets paid
- **No exclusivity required** — Owners can list on multiple platforms simultaneously
- **Transparent reporting** — Monthly dashboard showing bookings, revenue, and performance

3.4 Brokerage Revenue Projections (at 35% Commission)

Growth Phase	Listed Vessels	Avg Booking s/Vessel/Mo	Avg Booking	Monthly Gross	Our 35%	Annual Commission
Launch (Mo 1-6)	5	3	\$800	\$12,000	\$4,200	\$25,200
Growth (Mo 7-12)	15	4	\$850	\$51,000	\$17,850	\$107,100
Scale (Yr 2)	30	5	\$900	\$135,000	\$47,250	\$567,000
Mature (Yr 3)	50	5	\$950	\$237,500	\$83,125	\$997,500

3.5 Brokerage Costs (Incremental)

Expense	Monthly	Annual
Payment processing (Stripe ~2.9% + \$0.30)	Passed to booking	\$0 net

Expense	Monthly	Annual
Platform hosting & maintenance	\$50 - \$200	\$600 - \$2,400
Customer support (scaling)	\$0 - \$2,000	\$0 - \$24,000
Owner onboarding & photography	\$200 - \$1,000	\$2,400 - \$12,000
Marketing & SEO	\$500 - \$2,000	\$6,000 - \$24,000
Insurance (E&O; / liability)	\$200 - \$500	\$2,400 - \$6,000
Total	\$950 - \$5,700	\$11,400 - \$68,400

Brokerage margins are significantly higher — no vessel costs, no crew, no fuel. Pure platform economics.

4. Combined Business Model — Total Picture

Year 1 (Moderate Scenario)

Revenue Stream	Annual Revenue	Annual Costs	Net Profit
Own Vessel Charters	\$151,200	\$120,000	\$31,200
Brokerage Commissions (10 vessels avg @ 35%)	\$65,100	\$30,000	\$35,100
Total	\$216,300	\$150,000	\$66,300

Year 2 (Growth Scenario)

Revenue Stream	Annual Revenue	Annual Costs	Net Profit
Own Vessel Charters (2 vessels)	\$260,000	\$210,000	\$50,000
Brokerage Commissions (30 vessels @ 35%)	\$567,000	\$50,000	\$517,000
Total	\$827,000	\$260,000	\$567,000

Year 3 (Scale Scenario)

Revenue Stream	Annual Revenue	Annual Costs	Net Profit
Own Vessel Charters (3 vessels)	\$400,000	\$320,000	\$80,000

Revenue Stream	Annual Revenue	Annual Costs	Net Profit
Brokerage Commissions (50 vessels @ 35%)	\$997,500	\$68,000	\$929,500
Total	\$1,397,500	\$388,000	\$1,009,500

Key insight: At 35% commission, the brokerage model becomes massively profitable by Year 2. Own-vessel operations provide credibility and baseline revenue; the platform provides scalable, high-margin income. The brokerage alone could be a \$1M+/year revenue stream by Year 3.

5. Roles & Responsibilities

Ciaran's Domain (Business Build-Out)

Area	Responsibility
Website & Platform Development	Full ownership — build, maintain, iterate
SEO & Digital Marketing	Strategy and execution driving organic bookings
AI Automations & Agent Build-Out	Inquiry responder, review management, GetMyBoat auto-draft, consulting-grade AI systems
Content Creation & Management	Social media, blog, video, brand storytelling
Google My Business Management	GBP optimization, posts, reviews, local SEO
Brokerage Platform	Owner listing pages, commission tracking, dashboards
Payment Processing	Stripe integration, invoicing, financial reporting
Booking Management System	Online booking flow, calendar, confirmations
Networking & Business Development	Attending networking events, building partnerships
Owner Recruitment (Brokerage)	Shared with Josh
Customer Service	Shared with Josh

Josh's Domain (Capital & Operations)

Area	Responsibility
Vessel Purchase/Financing	100% of capital for vessel acquisition
Slip/Marina Fees	Monthly marina costs
Insurance	Commercial charter insurance

Area	Responsibility
Maintenance & Repairs	Vessel upkeep, winterization, haul-outs
Captain/On-Water Operations	Captains to operate and manage the vessel
Fuel & Consumables	Per-trip fuel and supplies
USCG Licensing & Compliance	Regulatory requirements, safety equipment
Owner Recruitment (Brokerage)	Shared with Ciaran — marina network relationships
Customer Service	Shared with Ciaran

6. Legal & Compliance Considerations

- Form LLC in Florida (or confirm existing entity)
- Operating agreement specifying profit splits, decision rights, exit clauses
- Commercial charter insurance (vessel + liability)
- USCG licensing requirements (6-pack or OUPV for captain)
- FL state sales tax on charter services (currently 7.5% in Hillsborough)
- Platform terms of service & liability waivers for brokerage listings
- Errors & Omissions insurance for brokerage operations
- Payment processing compliance (PCI via Stripe)
- Independent contractor agreements for brokerage owners

7. Risk Analysis

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Low booking volume (seasonality)	Medium	High	Diversify with sunset cruises, corporate events, off-season pricing
Vessel damage/breakdown	Medium	High	Commercial insurance, maintenance schedule, reserve fund
Partner disagreement	Low	High	Clear operating agreement, buyout clause, dispute resolution
Regulatory changes	Low	Medium	Stay current with USCG/FL requirements, industry associations

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Platform competition (GetMyBoat, Boatsetter)	High	Medium	Local focus, lower fees, superior SEO, personal service
Brokerage owner churn	Medium	Medium	Deliver bookings quickly, maintain relationships, low friction
Liability from brokerage bookings	Medium	High	E&O; insurance, clear ToS, owner responsibility agreements

8. Competitive Advantages

1. **Local SEO moat** — Tampa Bay focused content and optimization vs. national platforms
2. **AI-powered operations** — Automated inquiry responses, review management reduce overhead
3. **Full-service justifies premium** — 35% commission but owners do zero marketing, booking, or customer service work
4. **Owner-operator credibility** — We charter our own boats, not just middlemen
5. **Tech-forward** — Custom platform with AI, not a generic marketplace template
6. **Personal relationships** — Tampa Bay marina network, local owner recruitment
7. **Multiple acquisition models** — Can scale fleet through co-ownership, syndicate investors, or owner partnerships without over-leveraging

9. Next Steps

1. Ciaran & Josh align on ownership split and capital contributions
2. Consult attorney for LLC operating agreement
3. Define vessel target (type, size, price range)
4. Build brokerage listing features on yachtawaynow.com
5. Create owner onboarding package (photography, listing template, commission agreement)
6. Recruit first 5 brokerage owners from Tampa Bay marina contacts
7. Launch marketing push — local SEO, social media, marina partnerships

10. Decision Points for Discussion

- Confirm 60/40 (Josh/Ciaran) split — or adjust?
- Starting with 1 vessel or financing 2?

- Captain: Josh full-time, or hire captains to allow both partners flexibility?
- Brokerage commission rate: 15% flat or tiered?
- Timeline: When to launch brokerage vs. own-vessel operations?
- Minimum reserve fund amount before profit distributions begin?

11. Alternative Structure — Shared Overhead & Equity Buy-Up

As an alternative (or evolution) of the 60/40 split, both partners can share all overhead costs equally. Ciaran would use his profit share to cover his portion of overhead expenses AND contribute toward paying off the yacht. In return, Ciaran's ownership and equity in the business increases proportionally as he pays down the vessel.

How it works:

- All overhead costs (slip fees, insurance, maintenance, fuel, crew, etc.) are split between both partners
- Ciaran directs his profit distributions toward covering his share of overhead + paying down the yacht principal
- As Ciaran pays down more of the yacht, his equity stake in the LLC increases accordingly
- Josh's initial 60% ownership gradually adjusts as Ciaran buys in with real dollars

Example Equity Trajectory:

Milestone	Josh Equity	Ciaran Equity	Trigger
Launch	60%	40%	Josh funds vessel, Ciaran builds platform
Ciaran covers 25% of yacht cost	55%	45%	Profit reinvestment toward vessel payoff
Ciaran covers 50% of yacht cost	50%	50%	Equal financial + build contribution — max equity

Why this works for both partners:

- **For Josh:** Reduces his financial burden over time as Ciaran shares overhead and pays down the yacht. Less personal capital at risk as the business matures.
- **For Ciaran:** Creates a path to equal ownership (50/50) through reinvestment rather than upfront capital. Aligns incentives — the harder Ciaran works to drive bookings, the faster he earns equity.
- **For the business:** Both partners become increasingly invested (financially and operationally), reducing the risk of one partner disengaging.

Key terms to define:

- How is yacht payoff value tracked? (Monthly statements, shared ledger)
- At what intervals does equity adjust? (Quarterly, annually)
- Is there a cap on equity shift? (e.g., Ciaran maxes at 50%?)
- Does this apply to future vessels acquired by the LLC?